Mario

By Simon Rich

MARIO: It's-a me, Mario! I was-a working as a plumber in New York when I fell-a down a pipe and landed in the Mushroom Kingdom. Pretty soon, I was-a having all kinds of super-fun adventures, crushing Koopas, dodging hammers, and jumping through castle after castle. It's-a like my whole life was a game. I'd-a wake up each morning shouting, "Wahoo! Yiiiippeee! Here we go!"*

INTRODUCTION

VOICE OVER: *40 years ago, the Mushroom Kingdom was invaded by the Koopa, a tribe of turtles famous for their black magic. The peace-loving Mushroom People were turned into stones and bricks, and the Kingdom fell into ruin. The only one who could undo the magic spell was Princess Peach, daughter of the Mushroom King. Unfortunately, she was in the hands of Bowser, King of the Koopa! It was up to Mario to free Princess Peach. (chants Free Princess Peach, Free Princes Peach)*

Wait . . . You don't know who Mario is??? 2025 marks the 40th anniversary of the original Super Mario Brothers video game, but Mario isn't just a video game character — he's a global icon! He is so famous that even the Prime Minister of Japan dressed up as Mario for the closing ceremony of the 2016 Summer Olympics!

But I'll give you the inside scoop. Mario's exciting, "super-fun" life is hitting a very quiet, middle-age crisis. . . Decades of running, jumping, and smashing bricks with his head have taken a toll.

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MARIO: **(Pg 15-32)** I'm-a 40 years old. I wasn't-a really thinking about it much. Just another birthday, right? Then it's-a like the reality of the thing just hit me. "Mamma mia, I'm-a going to be middle-aged."

Turning 40 forces you to take-a stock of how you're doing. And to be honest, I'm-a not doing so great. I guess the best way to explain it is-a to start from the beginning of last week. Basically, I wake up, and it's-a, like, I can't-a move my back. Like, at all. So I go to Dr. Mario (no relation) and I'm-a in this tiny room for hours, doing all kinds of tests

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that I've-a never done before, and finally Dr. Mario comes back holding some X-rays, and he says that between the jumping and the running and the smashing the bricks with my head, I've-a basically given myself arthritis. And he says, "We need-a to schedule the surgery, Mario. The one we've been-a talking about. To fuse-a your spine. Recovery's-a going to be brutal, but the alternative is you could-a end up in a wheelchair. You could lose-a your ability to walk."

And he gives me his card and writes his cell phone number on it, and I'm-a thinking, "Mamma mia, it must be serious if he's-a giving me his private line." And I walk out of his office. I check-a my phone and there's-a, like, 20 missed calls from the Princess. *(heavy sigh)* I call her back and she starts-a going off on me for being out of touch all day, and I'm about to hang up when she tells me she's-a been kidnapped by a Koopa. *(rolls his eyes)*

Lately I've started to think she's been getting kidnapped by Koopas on purpose. The first few times it happened, I was-a, like, "Okay, that's a weird coincidence." But then it happened, like, literally thousands more times. *(to Princess Peach)* "If you know that the Koopas are after the *Princess,* why do you walk around wearing a *crown*?"

PRINCESS PEACH: Oh, so you're saying I was *asking for it*? *Because of the way that I was dressed?*

MARIO: You know what? If you want to get-a me canceled, go ahead! *(to audience)* Honestly, sometimes I fantasize about that since it would give me an excuse to stop. I wouldn't even do an apology, I'd-a just go off the grid, because at this point I'm-a so tired, I'd just be, like, "Great, I'm out! Wahoo! Yiiiippeee!" You know?

So anyway, she texts-a me the address of this castle she's trapped in, and it's-a, like, seven worlds away. And my back -- I have, at most, like, two days of mobility left before I'm-a going to be paralyzed. *(to Princess Peach)* I'm-a sorry, but I can't save you this time.

PRINCESS PEACH: *(shocked, then calculating)* Guess I'll call Devon.

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MARIO: *(to audience)* Devon -- he's-a this DJ who's, like, 22 at most, super tall and thin, with all the piercings and the neck tattoo. It's-a like she has this ***power*** over me. Still, after all these years. *(to Princess Peach)* Hey, baby. Relax. It's-a me, Mario.*(to audience)* And her voice gets soft, and she asks if I'm-a coming to save her or not. *(to Princess Peach)* Of course. Just wait on your floating block over the fire. I'll-a think of something.

So I'm-a frantically searching message boards about back pain, and there's this miracle device from Europe -- an electronic belt that takes-a all the pressure off your spine. But it's-a going to cost $10,000. And I've-a got, like, 5 coins in my checking account.

I know what you're-a thinking: "How does *Super Mario* go broke? You collected ***entire rooms*** of coins! What happened?" And the answer is-a simple: I trusted a close personal friend *(stage whispers "Yoshi")* to manage-a my money. And I know I deserve-a some of the blame for not catching on, because by the end he had his own island, and safari, and even Yoshi's World. I mean, this guy got so rich he had his own ***private world*** named after him.

There's-a only one move I can make. I've-a got no choice but go see my brother. So, look, here's-a the deal with Luigi. I'm-a glad he got sober, but now he and his husband, Kwame, does 4 hours of yoga every day. *(without excitement)* Wahoo. Yippee.

So, I walk up to their fancy gate and ring the stupid intercom: "It's-a me, Mario." And Kwame's, like, "Mario, what a pleasant surprise!" I guess that he's-a loaded, because Luigi is a professional sunbather now, and their driveway, it's-a, like, Tesla, Tesla, Tesla. So I tell-a them how the Princess is-a trapped, and I need to buy this spine belt, but I've-a got no money—But instead of writing me a check, Kwame says there's-a "no shame" in aging out of professional rescuing, and it's-a not too late for me to transition into something less physically demanding. And he hands-a me this book

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called *What Color Is Your Parachute?* And Luigi gives me a big thumbs-up, like I've-a just won an extra life.

KWAME: What would you say is your most marketable skill?

MARIO: I don't know, fighting Koopas?

KWAME: We ***could*** focus on your combat skills. But I think it might widen the net if we highlight your experience with plumbing. And he writes up this cover letter that's-a designed to turn "the negative into a positive":

MARIO: *(reading aloud) Dear prospective employer,*

I am writing to apply for the position of plumber at your company. Plumbing is a lifelong passion of mine. After beginning my career in New York City, I took a multi-year hiatus to the Mushroom Kingdom in order to improve my knowledge of pipes. Now I am ready to jump back in the game.

Sincerely, Mario

All my adventures, the entirety of my adult life, boils down to a "hiatus"? *(to Luigi)* Listen, I really appreciate all this great advice, but today the main thing is, I need-a to borrow some money, so I can buy this spine belt and save the Princess from the Koopa.

LUIGI: *(long silence, then removes his hat and launches into a rehearsed speech)* Mario, we want to help you, but we don't-a think we've-a been helping you in the right way. And that's-a why, for your sake and ours, we have-a decided to put up some financial boundaries.

MARIO: And as I'm-a hobbling out of their dumb gate, I start to think about my relationship with the Princess. Did I really want to be with her? Or was her love just a [way] to prove-a to myself that I had worth -- That, despite my immigrant background, I was-a still deserving of love? I'd-a been with the Princess for decades, but it's not like we'd-a ever actually connected. I barely even saw her, except for a few seconds after each rescue, and even then, it's-a not like we had deep

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conversations—we just stood next to each other, staring straight ahead, while some text scrolled anticlimactically over our heads, followed by Japanese names.

I pull out Dr. Mario's card, and call-a his personal number. *(on phone)* "It's-a me, Mario. I need help." *(to audience)* And within thirty minutes I'm-a in his office signing consent forms for "anterior lumbar interbody fusion."

DR. MARIO: You're going to need someone to wash your body and help-a you use-a the bathroom. For the first 12 weeks of recovery you're-a going to have zero mobility. Do you-a have a partner who can help you?

MARIO: And by now the Princess has straight-up blocked my number. I guess she did end up calling Devon, because she's-a posting all these pictures on social media, tagged, like, #realhero and #waybetterthanmario. And Dr. Mario, he's-a walking me through the different options when Luigi jumps through the window. It turns out someone from Dr. Mario's office called them, because they were-a listed as my emergency contacts.

LUIGI: We knew how much physical pain you were-a in, but we had no idea you were suffering so much emotionally. We love you, and we're-a with you for the long haul, no matter what it takes.

MARIO: And I'm-a looking up at these guys, because I've-a been playing the game for 40 years, but this is the first time that it's-a me who's being rescued. *(wipes a tear, beat)*

Now it's-a the night before the surgery, and it's-a gonna be a long time before I can jump or even walk. And the truth is, I'm-a never going to be "Super Mario" again. I'm-a going to just be plain regular Mario, a middle-aged guy with a slight limp.

But maybe getting older's not all bad. My whole life I've-a struggled with body stuff, like my weight and how I look-a naked. It's-a why I wear the overalls even when it makes no sense for what I'm doing. Like, why can't a short fat guy be sexy? *(does some sexy moves)* I feel-a sexy, and I'm not afraid to say I feel-a sexy. Deal-a with it. *(becomes self-conscious and returns to his narrative)*

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I'm-a ready for the challenge. Like, I really want to do a podcast. We even came up with a name for it (*The Next Level with Mario*). And Luigi's going to read-a the commercials, and Kwame's-a going to be my first guest. *(long beat as he reflects)* These past 40 years, I've-a had all kinds of ups and downs. I've-a won and lost, flown and fallen, jumped and been jumped on. I'm-a covered in scars and soon I'll have some more. But I'm-a not scared. I'm-a ready. Someday, I'll-a run out of continues, but in the meantime I've got plenty of lives left.

Here we go . . .

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AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier
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**Mario's famous lines by voiceover actor Charles Martinet can be found here:*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=76zQJFe4SBU

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